

Avgolemeno

Ingredients

Extra Virgin Olive Oil (I used Private Reserve Greek olive oil)

½ to 1 cup finely chopped carrots

½ to 1 cup finely chopped celery

½ to 1 cup finely chopped green onions

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

8 cups low-sodium chicken broth

2 bay leaves

1 cup rice

Salt and pepper

2 cooked boneless chicken breast pieces, shredded (about 6 to 8 oz store-bought rotisserie chicken will work)

½ cup freshly-squeezed lemon juice

2 large eggs

Fresh parsley for garnish (optional)

Method

Step 1:

In a large Dutch oven or heavy pot, heat 1 tbsp olive oil on medium-high. Add the carrots, celery and green onions, toss together to saute briefly then stir in the garlic.

Step 2:

Add the chicken broth and bay leaves then raise the heat to high. Once the liquid has come to a rolling boil, add the rice, salt and pepper.

Step 3:

Turn the heat to medium-low and simmer for 20 minutes or until the rice is tender. Now stir in the cooked chicken.

Step 4:

To prepare the egg-lemon sauce, in a medium bowl, whisk together the lemon juice and eggs. While whisking add 2 ladles-full of the broth from the cooking pot (this helps temper the eggs). Once fully combined, add the sauce to the chicken soup and stir. Remove from the heat immediately.

Step 5:

Garnish with fresh parsley, if you like. Serve hot with your favorite bread. Enjoy!

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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Spanakopita

1kg. fresh spinach, washed, dried, trimmed, and coarsely chopped
3 Tbs. extra-virgin olive oil
1 bunch scallions (about 3 oz. or 10 small), white and light-green parts only, trimmed and finely chopped
2 cups crumbled feta cheese (10 oz.)
1/2 cup finely grated Greek kefalotyri cheese or Parmigiano-Reggiano
2 large eggs, lightly beaten
1/2 cup finely chopped fresh dill
1/3 cup finely chopped fresh flat-leaf parsley
1/4 tsp. freshly grated nutmeg
Kosher or fine sea salt

For the assembly:

1/3 cup extra-virgin olive oil for brushing; more as needed
Eighteen 9x14-inch sheets frozen phyllo dough, thawed and at room temperature
2 tsp. milk

TIP:
Phyllo dries out very fast and becomes brittle when exposed to the air. Check out our test kitchen tips for working with it.
Position a rack in the center of the oven and heat the oven to 375°F.

Make the filling: Heat a 10-inch straight-sided saute pan over medium-high heat. Add a few large handfuls of the spinach and cook, tossing gently with tongs. As the spinach starts to wilt, add the rest a few handfuls at a time. Cook until all the spinach is wilted and bright green, about 4 minutes. With a slotted spoon, transfer the spinach to a colander set in a sink. Let cool slightly and squeeze with your hands to extract as much of the remaining liquid as you can.

Wipe the pan dry with a paper towel. Heat the oil in the pan over medium heat. Add the scallions and cook until soft and fragrant, about 4 minutes. Stir in the spinach, turn off the heat, and let cool for 5 minutes. Then stir in the cheeses, eggs, dill, parsley, nutmeg, and 1/2 tsp. salt and mix thoroughly.

Assemble the pie: With a pastry brush, lightly coat the bottom and sides of a 9x13x2-inch baking pan with some of the oil. Working quickly, lightly oil one side of a phyllo sheet and lay it in the pan oiled side up and off center so that it partially covers the bottom and reaches halfway up one long side of the pan (the edge on the bottom of the pan will be about 1 inch from the side). Lightly oil the top of another phyllo sheet and lay it oiled side up and off center so it reaches halfway up the other long side of the pan. (If your pan has sloped sides, the sheets may be slightly longer than the bottom of the pan; if so, let the excess go up one short side of the pan and then alternate with subsequent sheets.) Repeat this pattern with 4 more phyllo sheets.

Next, lightly oil the tops of 3 phyllo sheets and layer them oiled side up and centered in the pan. Spread the filling evenly over the last layer.

Repeat the oiling and layering of the remaining 9 phyllo sheets over the filling in the same way you layered the previous 9. With the oiled bristles of the pastry brush, push the edges of the phyllo down around the sides of the pan to enclose the filling completely.

With a sharp knife, score the top phyllo layer into 24 rectangles, being careful not to cut all the way through to the filling. Using the same pastry brush, brush the milk along all the score marks (this will keep the phyllo from flaking up along the edges of the squares). Bake the spanakopita until the top crust is golden brown, 35 to 45 minutes. Let cool until just warm. Cut out the rectangles carefully along the score marks and serve.

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COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

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MAROULOSALATA

INGREDIENTS

2 hearts of romaine
4 green onions
1/2 bunch dill
1/2 bunch mint
1/2 cup crumbled feta cheese

For the Dressing

Juice of 1 large lemon
Salt
1/2 teaspoon dried oregano
1/3 cup extra virgin olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Prepare a large mixing bowl with ice water. Thinly slice the romaine lettuce, then add to the ice water for 5 minutes to crisp while you prepare the dressing and remaining ingredients.

Step 2: Trim and finely chop the green onions (both the white and green parts). Finely chop the dill and mint leaves, discarding the stem.

Step 3: Make the dressing. In a medium mixing bowl, add the lemon juice, a large pinch of kosher salt, and the oregano and whisk to combine. Continue whisking as you drizzle in the extra virgin olive oil. Whisk until emulsified. Set aside for now.

Step 4: Drain the salad from the ice water and dry very thoroughly. A salad spinner helps if you have one, or use paper towels. Add to a large serving bowl, along with the chopped herbs, and feta. Give everything a gentle toss.

Step 5: Just before serving, give the dressing one more quick whisk and pour it all over the salad. Mix well (or use your hands to massage the salad and coat it well with the dressing). Serve immediately.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

AMPELOFASOLIA SALATA

INGREDIENTS

Water
450gms green beans, trimmed
Salt and pepper, to taste
Crushed red pepper flakes, optional, to taste
100gms quality crumbled feta cheese, to taste
2 tbsp (or more to your liking) pitted olives, chopped
Handful of cherry tomatoes, cut in half

For dressing

2 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
2 tbsp freshly squeezed lemon juice
1 to 2 garlic cloves, minced
2 tbsp chopped fresh dill
1/2 tsp sweet Spanish paprika
Salt and pepper, to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Prepare dressing. In a small bowl, whisk together extra virgin olive oil, lemon juice, garlic, fresh dill, Spanish paprika, pinch of salt and pepper. Set aside for now.

Step 2: Bring a large pot filled with water to a boil. Add green beans. Cook for 5 minutes, then, keep the pot of boiling water going, but using tongs, transfer green beans to an ice bath (a bowl of ice and ice cold water) for 5 minutes. Return beans to boiling water to finish cooking until tender, about 10 more minutes or so. Drain well.

Step 3: Transfer warm beans to a mixing bowl. Add the chopped tomatoes, toss with a little salt and pepper. Give the dressing a quick stir to combine well, then pour over the green beans. Toss again to coat.

Step 4: Transfer to a serving platter. Sprinkle crushed pepper flakes and crumbled feta. Top with chopped olives. Serve at room temperature.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Grilled Lemon & Chicken Skewers

Ingredients

800gms, skinless deboned chicken thighs, trimmed of excess fat
1 teaspoon salt
2 Tbsp plain yogurt
2 cloves garlic, minced (about 2 teaspoons)
1 Tbsp minced fresh oregano 1/2 teaspoons dried oregano
1/8 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper
1 teaspoon lemon juice
1 Tbsp olive oil plus more for the grill
2 lemons, thinly sliced

Method

Step 1 Soaking bamboo or wooden skewers, place them in water to soak while you prepare the recipe. You'll need either 4 flat skewers or 8 regular round skewers.

Step 2 Cut chicken thigh into even chunks, then place in a bowl and sprinkle with salt. Add the yogurt, minced garlic, oregano, pepper, lemon juice, and olive oil to the bowl with the chicken, stir to combine. Marinate for 30 minutes to an hour - the longer the better.

Step 3 Thread skewers with chicken and lemon slices: Prepare your grill for direct high heat. While the grill is heating, prepare the skewers. Use either flat bamboo or metal skewers or double up regular bamboo skewers so that the chicken is easier to turn on the grill. Thread the chicken pieces onto the skewers with a lemon slice folded over like a taco between each piece of chicken.

Step 4 When the grill is ready brush the grill grates with a little olive oil (use a paper towel folded over several times and dipped in olive oil, hold with tongs). Brush some olive oil over the chicken skewers as well. Place the chicken skewers directly over the hottest part of the grill and cover the grill.

Step 5 Cook for 5 to 6 minutes to sear on one side (about 2 to 3 minutes), then turn the chicken skewers over to the other side, cover and cook 2 to 3 minutes more, until the chicken is browned and just cooked through.

Step 6 Remove from grill and serve immediately with tzatziki sauce.

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COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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TIROKEFTTERI

INGREDIENTS

4 red bell peppers
1/4 cup extra-virgin olive oil
2tbsp red wine vinegar
2 garlic cloves, peeled
2 cups crumbled feta cheese
1-2 red chili (optional)

METHOD

Step 1:

Char peppers directly over gas flame or in broiler until blackened on all sides. Enclose in paper bag 10 minutes. Peel, seed, and quarter peppers.

Step 2: Puree peppers, oil, garlic, red wine vinegar and cheese in processor (add the chili at this stage if using). Season with salt and pepper. Chill at least 3 hours or overnight.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Lemony Roast Potatoes

Ingredients

1kg potatoes peeled and chopped into chunky wedges 6
garlic cloves crushed
1/2 cup chicken broth (or vegetable broth)
2tbsp white wine
1/2 cup olive oil
1 large lemon, zested and juiced (medium to large)
1 tablespoon oregano dried
1 teaspoon salt
1/2 teaspoon pepper
parsley for sprinkling at the end (completely optional)

Method

Step 1:

Grease a large baking dish or tray with olive oil and preheat the oven to 400F / 200C.

Step 2

Cut the potatoes into chunky wedges and set aside.

Step 3

In a large bowl combine the garlic, stock, white wine, olive oil, lemon juice & zest, oregano and salt and pepper. Stir well, then add the potatoes and coat well. Pour the potato wedges into the dish/tray in an even layer.

Step 4

Bake uncovered for 45 minutes. Then stir well, turning all the potatoes and spooning over the liquid. Bake again for another 45 minutes or until the potatoes are well browned.

Step 5

Scatter with parsley (if using) and serve with some of the delicious juices. Don't forget the burnt crispy bits on the bottom of the pan.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

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Kolokithokeftedes

Ingredients

500 g zucchini, grated
2 spring onions, only the green part, thinly sliced
1 bunch of mint, only the leaves, finely chopped 1/3 bunch of dill, finely chopped
1 bunch of basil, finely chopped grated zest of 2 limes
1 levelled teaspoon ground cumin
2 pinches chili flakes
200 g feta cheese, crumbled 2
eggs
80 g all-purpose flour
2-3 tablespoons olive oil

For Frying: 1/2 inch sunflower oil (or canola oil)

Method

Step 1: Line the bowl with a thin kitchen towel. Grate the zucchini on to the towel in the bowl, using the large blades of a hand grater.

Sprinkle with a generous amount of salt to help the zucchini release more moisture. Mix and squeeze the mixture with your hands. Wrap in the towel and squeeze very tightly in your hands to release as much liquid as possible. The less moisture the zucchini mixture has, the crunchier your fritters will become! Transfer from towel to a clean, dry bowl.

Finely chop the green part of the spring onions. Finely chop the mint leaves, dill and basil and add them all to **Step 2:** the bowl. Add the lime zest, cumin, chili flakes, crumbled feta and 2 eggs. Mix until all of the ingredients are completely combined.

Add the flour and mix just to combine. Do not overmix.

Step 3:

Place a nonstick pan over medium to high heat. Add 2-3 tablespoons of olive oil. Pick up spoonfuls of the mixture and carefully add them to the hot oil. Do not crowd your pan. Gently press down on the patties to spread them out a little.

Step 4: Fry on both sides until nice and golden, just like pancakes! When ready, transfer to a plate lined with paper **Step 5:** towels so they can drain from excess oil. Repeat the same process until all of your mixture has turned in to crunchy fritters.

THE COOKERY

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024. *by The Secret Jozzi Chef*

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Mussels Saganaki

Ingredients

1 1/2 kg mussels, washed and debearded
1 glass white wine (dry) 20 cherry tomatoes
1 pepper
1 red onion
1 spring of celery
1 carrot
2 cloves of garlic
1 bunch fresh parsley
100g feta cheese (optional) 1/2 cup olive oil

Chop the red onion, pepper, celery, and carrot into tiny (0.5cm x 0.5cm) chunks.

Method

Heat a large saucepan into high heat and add the olive oil. Pour in the vegetable mixture and sauté, until tender.

Cut the cherry tomatoes into halves and add them into the pan along with the mussels and the feta cheese (crushed).

Pour in the white wine and cook at high heat, with the lid on, for 8-10 minutes.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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TZATZIKI

INGREDIENTS

1 medium cucumber, peeled, sliced in half and seeded, and finely chopped
1/8 teaspoon plus 1/4 teaspoon salt
1 cup plain yogurt
1 tablespoon olive oil
1 teaspoon fresh lemon juice or white wine vinegar
1 teaspoon minced fresh dill or oregano leaves
1 teaspoon minced garlic

METHOD

Step 1

Put the cucumber in a strainer set over a bowl. Sprinkle with 1/8 teaspoon salt and allow to drain for 20-minutes. Now wrap it in a clean tea towel and carefully wrap the cucumber tightly to squeeze out the water.

Step 2

Put the yogurt in another strainer set over a bowl and drain for 1 hour. Combine the cucumber and yogurt in a bowl with the remaining ingredients and stir well.

Step 3

Cover and chill for at least 30-minutes before serving.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

PANTZAROSALATA

INGREDIENTS

400g strained yogurt
2 medium raw or pre-cooked beets
2-4 sheets minced garlic (depending on
how strong you want it)
Salt to taste
1/2 cup finely chopped walnuts
1 tbsp chopped dill
2-3 tbsp. vinegar
5-6 tbsp. olive oil

METHOD

STEP 1:

Using gloves grate the beet on the fine side of a grater.

STEP 2:

In a bowl add your yoghurt, finely minced or grated garlic, salt, vinegar, finely chopped dill and olive oil. Whisk to combine.

STEP 3:

Add the finely grated beet to the dressing and stir will to combine. Taste and adjust seasoning.

STEP 4:

Top with the roasted walnut pieces and some extra dill, serve as a dip or as a salad besides roasted meats.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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PRAWNS SAGANAKI

INGREDIENTS

1 tablespoon olive oil
1 small brown onion finely chopped
2 garlic cloves minced
½ teaspoon sugar
1 teaspoon dried herbs like thyme or oregano
¼ teaspoon salt
½ red chilli finely chopped
1 tablespoon tomato paste
400 g tinned chopped tomatoes
60 ml dry white wine
1 kgs king prawns raw, defrosted if frozen
100 g feta crumbled
1 tablespoon parsley finely chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat the olive oil in a medium oven-proof pan (like cast iron skillet) over low-medium heat. Add the finely chopped onions and saute for 5 minutes until softened, but not browned.

Step 2: Add the garlic, salt, sugar, dried herbs and chilli and stir for a minute.

Step 3: Tip in a tin of chopped tomatoes, tomato paste, white wine and stir. Bring the sauce to a gentle simmer and carry on cooking for 20 minutes until the sauce has reduced by about half.

Step 4: In a separate pan add a little olive oil and heat, then season your prawns with salt and pepper and pan fry on each side for two minutes until blushed, remove and set aside while you finish the rest of the prawns. Return all the prawns to the hot pan and flambe with the 1/4 brandy. Remove prawns and allow to cool slightly before peeling the prawns..

Step 5: Add the brandy and any prawn juices to the tomato sauce and then add the prawn meat cut into large chunks to the tomato sauce.

Step 6: Take the saganaki dish off of the heat and crumble the feta cheese on top. Scatter the parsley on top and serve with rice or crusty sourdough bread!

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

SOFT FLATBREADS

INGREDIENTS

600gms cake flour
1 tsp baking powder
2 tsp fine salt
140ml extra virgin olive oil
200ml yoghurt
170ml water
2 tsp zaatar / finely chopped rosemary /
oregano (optional)

Oil to cook

t

METHOD

STEP 1:

Add your flour and baking powder to a large bowl, to it add the salt and if you are adding any herbs add them now and mix with a whisk to distribute.

STEP 2:

In a small pot over medium high heat, add the oil and water. As soon as it begins to bubble switch it off and add the yoghurt and stir to combine.

STEP 3:

Add this mixture to the flour and mix with a spoon until it begins to form a dough, then take over with your hands. Move the dough to the counter and knead for a few minutes until you have a nice smooth dough. Add the dough back to a bowl and cover with clingwrap and let the dough rest on the counter for 30-minutes to an hour.

STEP 4:

Now divide the dough into 8 equal parts (approx 130gms each), roll into a ball, and then with a rolling pin, roll until about 2mm thick. Turn 45 each time your roll to help you achieve a round shape.

STEP 5:

Now heat a heavy based frying over medium high heat until hot, then brush each wrap with some oil and cook in the pan for about 2-minutes a side until dotted with brown spots and cooked through, flip and repeat on the opposite side. Keep warm between two plates lined with a clean dishcloth – the steam will help keep them nice and soft.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Lamb Moussaka

Ingredients

2 large eggplant, thinly sliced Olive oil cooking spray
1 tablespoon olive oil
1 medium brown onion, finely chopped
2 garlic cloves, crushed
800g lamb mince
420g can crushed tomatoes
1 teaspoon ground cinnamon
1/2 teaspoon ground allspice
1/3 cup grated pizza cheese
Lemon wedges, to serve
WHITE SAUCE
75g butter
1/3 cup plain flour
2 cups milk

Method

Step 1 or brush eggplant with oil. Heat a large frying pan over medium-high heat. Cook eggplant, in batches, for 2 to 3 minutes each side or until browned. Transfer to a large plate.

Step 2 Oil in a large saucepan over medium-high heat. Add onion and garlic. Cook, stirring, for 5 minutes or until onion has softened. Add mince. Cook, stirring with a wooden spoon to break up mince, for 6 to 8 minutes or until browned. Add tomatoes, cinnamon and allspice. Bring to the boil. Reduce heat to medium-low. Simmer for 30 minutes or until sauce is thick and liquid has evaporated.

Step 3 While, make sauce Melt butter in a saucepan over medium-high heat. Add flour. Cook, stirring, for 1 minute or until bubbling. Gradually stir in milk. Bring to the boil. Reduce heat to medium. Cook, stirring, for 5 minutes or until mixture has thickened. Remove from heat.

Step 4 Preheat oven to 180°C/160°C fan-forced. Grease an 8 cup-capacity ovenproof dish. Place one-third of the eggplant, slightly overlapping, over base of prepared dish. Spread half the meat sauce over eggplant. Repeat layers, ending with eggplant. Spread white sauce over eggplant. Sprinkle with cheese. Bake for 45 minutes or until golden. Stand 15 minutes. Serve with lemon wedges.

THE COOKERY

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TIROPITA

INGREDIENTS

8-10 sheets of phyllo pastry
340g feta cheese, crumbled
100g mild goats cheese,
120g Parmesan, or regato or Kefalograviera
2 egg, beaten
a splash of milk
fresh mint or dill, chopped (optional)
olive oil or melted butter
freshly ground pepper

METHOD

Step 1:

To prepare the tiropita, start by preparing the filling. Crush the feta cheese into a large bowl and add the grated cheese, the egg, a splash of milk, and season with freshly ground pepper. Mix well with a spoon to combine the ingredients. (At this point you can add some chopped fresh herbs if you like; some fresh dill or mint will surely lift the flavour).

Step 2:

Preheat the oven at 180C and start preparing the tiropita.

Step 3:

Spread one sheet of the phyllo dough on the kitchen counter and with a cooking brush drizzle with some melted butter or olive oil. Spread one more sheet on top and drizzle with some more butter.

Step 4:

Cut the sheets into three or four lanes (depending on if you like the tiropita to be small or larger). At the end of each lane add one tablespoon of the filling. Fold one corner to form a triangle and continue folding the triangle upon itself, until the entire piece of phyllo is used. Continue with the rest phyllo sheets and filling.

Step 5:

Oil the bottom of a large baking tray, place the tiropita and brush them with some melted butter on top. Bake in preheated oven at 180C for 25-30 minutes, until golden and crispy.

TO FOLD:

Cut each phyllo sheet into six, 5 cm strips along the long side. Brush generously with the melted butter. Add one tablespoon of the filling to one side of the long strip and begin to fold into a triangle as the diagram below suggests. Continue until you have used up all of the filling.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

KALAMARAKIA TIGANITA

INGREDIENTS

700g calamari (25 oz.)
100g bread flour (3.5 oz.)
50g semolina flour (1.5 oz.)
1 tbsp peppercorns (or ground pepper)
2 tbsps salt
1/2 tbsp paprika (optional)
1 tbsp oregano (optional)
vegetable oil for frying

METHOD

Step 1

To start clean the calamari and wash thoroughly. Using a sharp knife cut the calamari in slices, approx. 1 cm each. This will create the rings. Place the calamari rings on some paper towel to get rid of the excessive water.

Step 2

Prepare the seasoning for the fried calamari. In a blender add the seasoning and pulse until powdered. (Alternatively you can use a pestle.)

Step 3

In a large sandwich bag or tupperware add the flour and seasoning. Place in the sliced calamari and shake well to coat (you will need to do this in batches). Remove the calamari onto a plate, shaking of any excess flour.

Step 4

Into a medium sized frying pan pour enough vegetable oil to deep fry the calamari. Heat the oil to medium high heat until it begins to bubble. Test if the oil is hot enough by dipping one of the calamari rings in; if it sizzles the oil is ready. Fry the calamari in batches for about 2-3 minutes, until nicely golden.

Step 5

Remove the fried calamari using a slotted spoon and place on some paper towel to dry for 1-2 minutes. Have a taste and sprinkle with some more salt.

Step 6

Serve hot with some lemon wedges.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

KARIDOPITA

INGREDIENTS

For the cake

380g chopped walnut (13 ounces)
180g powdered Melba toast or
breadcrumbs
20g baking powder
1 flat tsp powdered nutmeg
2 tsp powdered cinnamon
1/2 tsp ground clove
200g butter
165g sugar
7 eggs (separated into whites and yolks)
zest of 1 orange
75ml brandy (1/3 of a cup)

For the syrup

2 cups sugar
100 grams honey (3.5 oz)
2 cups water
1 tsp vanilla extract
1 tbsp orange juice
1/4 of a cup cognac

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Use an electric mixer to mix the sugar and butter; mix at medium-high speed for at least 5 minutes, until smooth and creamy. Add the egg yolks, one at a time, whilst continue mixing; wait each time for each egg to be absorbed, before adding the next. Pour in the brandy and the orange zest and mix for 10 more seconds. Set aside.

Step 2: Into a large bowl, add the chopped walnut, the powdered Melba toast, the cinnamon, the clove, the nutmeg, the baking powder and blend with a spoon. (Chop the walnut, using a blender, but be careful not to powder it; the authentic greek walnut cake calls for roughly chopped walnuts.)

Step 3: Combine the two mixtures and blend, until smooth.

Step 4: Place the egg whites into the bowl of the electric mixer, along with a pinch of salt. Make sure your egg whites, bowl and whisk attachments are clean and free of any water. Whisk the egg whites until the mixture is very thick and glossy and a long trailing peak forms when the whisk is lifted (meringues).

Step 5: With a spatula add gradually the meringues into the mixture and blend with light circular movements from the bottom up.

Step 6: Butter the bottom and the sides of a round baking tray, approx 30cm diameter and bake in a preheated oven at 170C, for about 35 minutes, until nicely colored on the outside and baked through.

Step 7: Let the karidopita (greek walnut cake) to cool and then prepare the syrup. Add all the ingredients for the syrup into a pot, and boil, until the sugar has dissolved. Scar the cake into pieces, and slowly ladle the hot syrup over the cold cake, allowing time for each ladle of syrup to be absorbed.

Step 8: Let it cool down for a while, before serving. This Greek walnut cake is ideally served cold with some vanilla ice-cream aside. Enjoy!!

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

GIGANTES PLAKI

Extra-virgin olive oil

1/2 large onion, roughly chopped

1 large carrot, peeled and roughly chopped

1 celery stalk, roughly chopped

2 large garlic cloves, minced

Salt

1 can diced tomatoes, with juices

6 Tablespoons water

1/4 cup chopped flat-leaf parsley, plus more for garnish

1/2 Tablespoon fresh thyme leaves

3/4 teaspoon dried oregano

1/4 to 1/2 teaspoon red pepper flakes

1/4 teaspoon ground black pepper

1/8 to 1/4 teaspoon ground cinnamon

1 dried bay leaf

1 450g can butter beans, drained and rinsed (or the largest beans you can find)

Creamy feta cheese, crumbled

Rustic bread, for serving

Step 1: Preheat oven: Position a rack in the center of the oven and preheat the oven to 190C.

Step 2: Saute the vegetables: In a large oven-safe skillet set over medium-high heat, add 1/8 cup olive oil. Once the oil shimmers, add the onion, carrot, celery, and garlic. Season with a pinch of salt (about 1/4 teaspoon). Cook, stirring frequently, until the vegetables soften, 5-7 minutes.

Step 3: Add the tomatoes and spices: Add the tomatoes with their juices and the water. Season with another pinch of salt (about 1/4 teaspoon). Add the parsley, thyme, oregano, red pepper flakes, black pepper, cinnamon, and bay leaf.

Step 4: Add the beans: Stir in the beans and cook for 5 minutes over high heat. At this point, taste and adjust the seasoning to your liking, then transfer the mixture to the oven and bake until thickened and the top layer turns a light golden brown, 20 to 30 minutes.

Finish and serve: Remove and discard the bay leaf. Finish the dish with a drizzle of olive oil, a pinch of parsley, and a good sprinkle of feta. Serve with rustic bread.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

SARAGLI

Ingredients

For the syrup

500 g granulated sugar
300 g water
1 stick(s) cinnamon
50 g glucose
6 cloves
peel, of 1 lemon
1 tablespoon(s) lemon juice

For the saragli

400 g butter
150 g walnuts 150 g almonds
1 teaspoon(s) cinnamon
1/2 teaspoon(s) cloves, ground
900 g phyllo dough sheet
pistachios, ground, to serve

Method

For the syrup

1. In a pot, add the sugar, water, cinnamon stick, glucose syrup, cloves and lemon rind.
2. Place pot over medium heat.
3. In about 2-3 minutes, as soon as the sugar melts, remove pot from heat.
4. Add the lemon juice, stir and set aside to cool.

For saragli

- Step 1: Melt the butter in a saucepan over low heat.
- Step 2: In a food processor or using a mortar and pestle, grind the walnuts, almonds, cinnamon and cloves together. You don't want to finely grind them but you don't want to have large pieces because they will rip through the phyllo dough.
- Step 3: Transfer the filling to a bowl and transfer the melted butter to a separate bowl.
- Step 4: Preheat the oven to 160* C (320* F) Fan.
- Step 5: Spread out the phyllo dough on a clean working surface.
- Step 6: Lay one sheet of phyllo dough separately on your working surface. Drizzle with melted butter, making sure not to let the brush directly touch the phyllo.
- Step 7: Cover with another sheet of phyllo and drizzle with butter. Spread the filling over the entire surface.
- Step 8: Place two wooden sticks in the middle of the phyllo and roll the smaller side towards the middle, leaving an empty space at the edge.
- Step 9: Do not roll too tight and gently press the ends together towards the middle with your hands, creating folds in the phyllo and remove the sticks.
- Step 10: Brush a 30x40 cm baking pan with butter and add the saragli.
- Step 11: Drizzle with butter immediately and repeat the same process until the baking pan is full of saragli rolls.
- Step 12: When the pan is full, drizzle any leftover butter over the saragli rolls.
- Step 13: Bake for 70-90 minutes.
- Step 14: When ready, remove from oven and immediately pour the cool syrup over the scorching hot saragli rolls.
- Step 15: Allow them to soak up the syrup for 30 minutes.
- Step 16: Sprinkle with ground pistachio nuts and serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

www.facebook.com/secretjozichef

Keftedes

500g ground beef
200g ground pork
1 large red onion, grated
1 clove of garlic, minced
1 cup breadcrumbs
1 egg
1/4 of a cup chopped fresh parsley
6-7 leaves fresh mint (chopped)
2 tbsps olive oil
1/2 teaspoon oregano
salt and pepper
oil for frying
flour for dredging

Directions:

To prepare this traditional Greek meatballs recipe (keftedes), add all the ingredients into a large bowl and mix well (for about 5-10 minutes), squeezing with your hands, to allow the flavours to blend. (If the mixture isn't firm enough, add some more breadcrumbs). Cover the bowl with some plastic wrap and let it rest in the fridge for 1 hour.

Turn the mixture for the keftedes out of the fridge and roll into meatballs the size of a walnut (or bigger if you prefer). Dredge the rolled meatballs lightly in flour making sure to shake off any excess. Fry until nicely browned on all sides.

The traditional way of cooking Greek meatballs (keftedes) is frying them. Fry the keftedes in batches of 10-15 at a time, until nicely browned on all sides.

Instead of frying you can bake / grill the keftedes in the oven. Preheat the oven at 200C, place the keftedes on greased baking sheet about an inch apart. Bake for about 20 minutes, turning the meatballs upside down midway through cooking time. The grilled version is much lighter than the fried so theres not excuse to not trying it now!

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Pastitsio

Lasagne the way Greeks do it!!

Ingredients

Olive oil, to grease
2 tablespoons dried (packaged) breadcrumbs
1 x 500g pkt Macherroni elbows pasta
2 tablespoons olive oil
1kg beef mince
1 brown onion, coarsely chopped
3 garlic cloves, crushed
1 x 400g bottle passata
1 x can peeled plum tomatoes, chopped
1tsp dried origanum
1 tsp fresh chopped origanum
80ml (1/3 cup) water
1 teaspoon ground cinnamon
70g (1 cup) shredded parmesan

Bechamel sauce

80g butter
50g (1/3 cup) plain flour 1L (4 cups) milk
4 eggs, lightly whisked

Method

Preheat oven to 180°C. Brush a 6.5cm-deep, 26 x 33cm (base measurement) ovenproof dish with oil to grease. Add the breadcrumbs and shake to coat.

Cook the pasta in a large saucepan of salted boiling water following packet directions or until al dente. Drain. Return to the pan.

Meanwhile, heat half the oil in a frying pan over medium-high heat. Add half the mince and cook, stirring, for 3-4 minutes or until mince changes colour. Transfer to a heatproof bowl. Repeat with remaining mince, reheating the pan between batches.

Heat the remaining oil in the pan. Add the onion and garlic and cook, stirring, for 5 minutes or until onion is soft. Add the mince, passata, water and cinnamon and cook, stirring, for 5-8 minutes or until the sauce thickens slightly.

To make the bechamel sauce, melt the butter in a saucepan over medium heat until foaming. Add flour and cook, stirring, for 1 minute or until the mixture bubbles. Remove from heat. Gradually add the milk, stirring constantly until smooth. Place the pan over medium heat and cook, stirring constantly, until the sauce thickens. Remove from heat and whisk in the egg. Season with salt and pepper.

Add 310ml (1 1/4 cups) of the bechamel sauce to the pasta and stir until well combined. Place half the pasta mixture in the prepared pan. Spoon over the mince mixture. Top with the remaining pasta mixture. Spread the remaining bechamel sauce over the top. Sprinkle with parmesan. Bake for 45-50 minutes or until golden. Serve.

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